

stars. As the marquee gets crowded with more neon lit names, Katrina Kaif, Deepika Padukone, Sonam Kapoor and Asin Thottumkal, it is clear that though Bollywood is a man's world, when it comes to women, perhaps there is an infinitely greater pool of excellence. W. Somerset Maugham once said, in Hollywood, the women are all peaches. It makes one long for an apple occasionally. In Bollywood, no one is complaining especially as the top three male stars have now been around for almost two decades and the fourth is soon completing a decade in the spotlight. And the peaches are only getting peachier and prettier. Will the roles that come their way allow them to be more than mere props? Will women open movies, when even global superstars like Julia Roberts are floundering? Hey, there's no need to lose hope. Take a look at Meryl Streep, still kicking up her heels in *Mamma Mia* (made for \$52 million, it clocked \$609 million) and whipping up a feast in *Julie & Julia* (made for \$40 million, it clocked \$101 million), with nary a notable gent in sight. At the age of yes, you heard it right, 60.

The First Choice

Two actors who have defied the Barbie Doll diktat of Bollywood, fourth generation actor Kajol, 35, and Miss World-winning Aishwarya Rai Bachchan, 36, have more in common than their husbands, actors Ajay Devgn and Abhishek Bachchan respectively, being good friends. Both are selective about what they do, but then are completely committed when they do so. For Kajol, pairing once again with Shah Rukh Khan in Karan Johar's *My Name Is Khan* was enough to make the director emotional every time he looked through the camera. For Aishwarya, life, especially post-marriage, has been a series of searing performances, from Ashutosh Gowariker's *Jodhaa-Akbar* to Ram Gopal Varma's *Sarkar Raj*. Over the next few months, Aishwarya will be seen in Shankar's *Endhiran*, Mani Ratnam's *Raavan*, Sanjay Leela Bhansali's *Guzaarish* and Vipul Shah's *Action Replay*. Kajol, in the role of a mother who is devastated by the loss of her son in *My Name Is Khan*, and the wife who is cast aside for a younger model in the Indian remake of *Stepmom*, will have audiences

wishing to see more of her, just as it was after her last "come back" movie, *Fanaa*, in 2006. The two are examples of what Katherine Hepburn, an acting great whose career lasted several decades, once said: "It's life, isn't it? You plow ahead and make a hit. And you plow on and someone passes you. Then someone passes them. Time levels." Indeed, both Kajol and Aishwarya have been around long enough for the world to finally recognise that what they can do, no one else can.

Diva Duo

Kareena Kapoor, 29, and Priyanka Chopra, 27, embody the 21st century heroine in Bollywood. One comes from a movie dynasty and the other is beauty queen royalty. Both have done a canny mix of masala movies and art house winners. Both have demanding endorsement schedules and tabloid lives that ensure they

Priyanka Chopra, 28

The former beauty queen has advanced steadily to the top, from the bad girl of *Aitraaz* to the power woman of *Fashion*.

Kareena Kapoor, 29

Almost a decade in the business, and already she has a *Geet* and a *Dolly*. Ah, and pure commercial success as well.

